

Carry On, Mr. Bowditch

Chapter 1



Nat lay very still in the dark, trying to stay awake until his big brother, Hab, went to sleep. Nat wasn't quite sure, but he thought a good-luck spell worked better if you kept it secret. He stared out the window and watched the April breeze chase clouds across the stars. His eyelids sagged. That wouldn't do! He must stay awake to work his spell. His family needed good luck.

Why did they have so much bad luck? Was it because Father had lost his ship? Or was it because of the war? Ever since Nat could remember, the war had been going on. How long had it been? He counted back on his fingers to 1775. Four years since the war started.

His eyelids sagged again. He squinched them shut and opened them. Was Hab asleep now? Nat whispered, "Hab?"

Hab stirred and muttered, "Why don't you go to sleep?"

"I got to thinking about Salem."

Hab snorted. "You can't remember Salem. It's been four years since we moved away. Go to sleep."

Nat rubbed his eyes and stared out the window again. Four years since everything happened — since the war began, and Father lost his ship, and they moved away from Salem. How old was he then? He was four-from-six; he was two. He'd count up how old everybody had been; that would help him stay awake. Mary was four-from-thirteen; she was nine. Hab was four-from-eleven; he was seven. Lizza was four-from-eight; she was four. William was four-from-three; he was . . . he wasn't!

Hab sat up with a jerk. "What in the name of sense are you giggling about?"

"About William was four-from-three when we moved to Danvers."

"You and

to Danvers.
"You and your numbers! Look, Nat! We have to get up early tomorrow! Mr. Baker'll be here before sunup to help us move back to Salem. Now settle down and go to sleep!"

Nat sat up and leaned his head on his knees. "Will you answer just one question, Hab?"

"What is it?"

"Is it the best good-luck spell in the world to jingle silver in your pocket when you see the new moon?"

"Of course. But you have to have silver to jingle."

Nat thought of the shilling he'd found. He hugged his knees and grinned.

The next thing Nat heard was Hab's voice saying,

"Wake up, sleepy-head." He opened his eyes. It was morning. His good-luck spell! He'd missed it! His stomach felt scared.

Hab was standing by the bed, his dark hair wet and combed, a grin like Father's on his square face. He pulled the covers off Nat. "Come on, you little towhead."

Father tramped up the steep stairs, bending his dark head where the roof slanted, and stood with his arm around Hab's shoulders, smiling down at Nat. "Hab, it's a good thing you thought of him. He's so little we might have missed him. We might just have rolled him up in the covers and never found him till we got to Salem!"

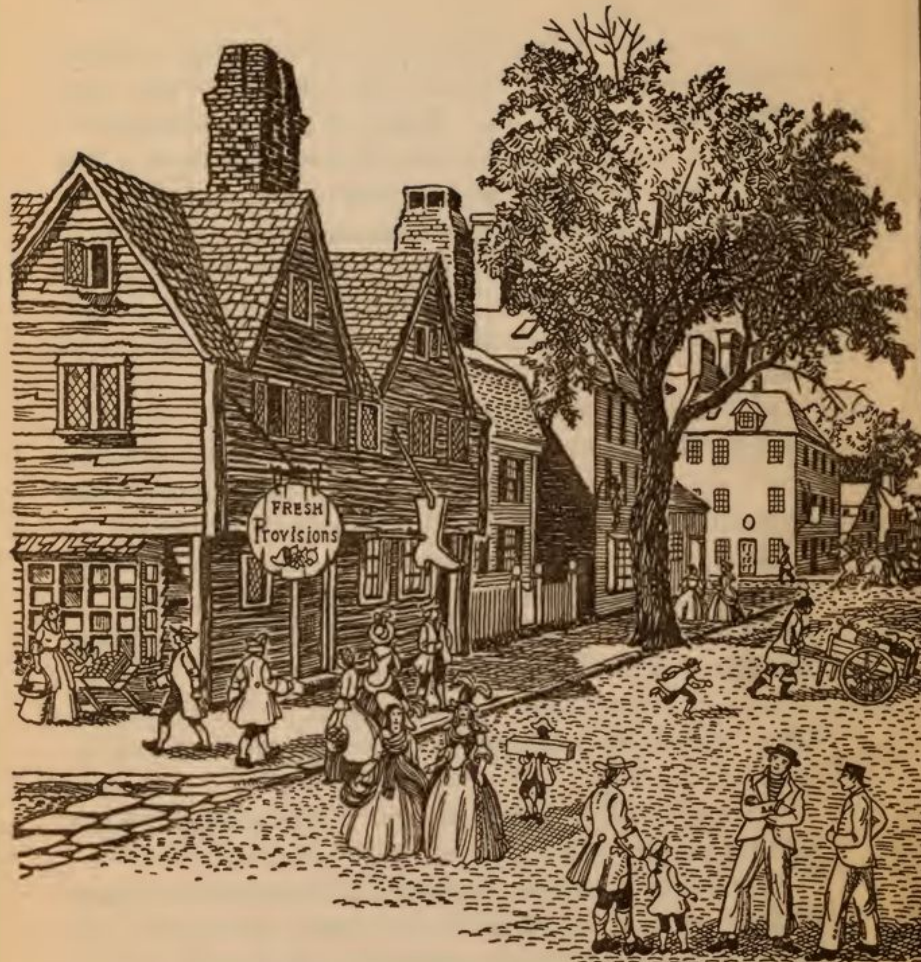
Nat laughed with them, but his stomach still felt scared. He scrambled out of bed, pulled on his trousers and shirt, and scuttled downstairs. His bowl of mush was waiting on the table. He said, "I'm not hungry."

Granny's sharp black eyes looked at him over her spectacles. "You get washed up and sit right down and eat. It isn't Christian to throw out good food, and I'm not going to carry that bowl of mush to Salem by hand."

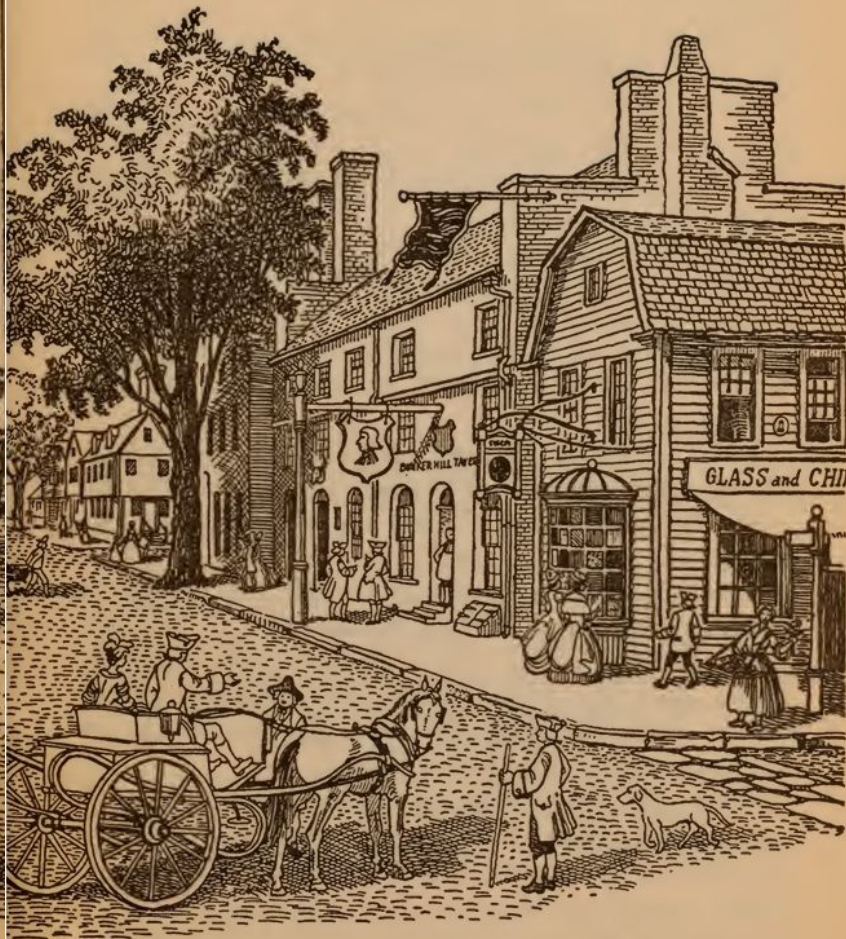
Mother smiled and hugged Granny. "He'll eat it. Come on, dear. Let's go see how they're getting along with the loading."

Granny nodded. "We'd better. Those men will make a hurrah's nest of it."

When they had gone, Nat tried to eat, but he couldn't swallow around the lump in his throat. He carried his bowl over in the corner where little William was playing by Sammy's cradle. He'd feed his breakfast to them so it wouldn't be wasted.



Essex Street in Salem 1776



He was just scraping his bowl, and Sammy was holding up his face like a robin waiting for a worm, when Lizza came in.

"Oh, Nat! If Granny knew you didn't eat your breakfast, you'd catch it!" Lizza whispered.

Nat grinned. "But you won't tell her. You keep secrets better than anybody."

"I have to keep your secrets. Some day you'll be bigger than I am." Lizza giggled.

Nat stood by Lizza to measure. She was only eight — just two years older — but a good head taller. "You're sure I'll be bigger?"

"Of course. Some day you'll be saying, 'Lizza, bring your head over here a minute. I want something to lean my elbow on!' "

Nat stuck out his chest and put his hands in his pockets. He felt something tied up in a rag. His shilling! "Lizza, when we get to Salem, I'll tell you a real secret! The biggest secret in the world."

It was late that afternoon when Mr. Baker's wagons crossed North River into Salem and drove to Turner's Lane. Granny called, "See that big house, children? Down near the water? Your great-great-great-grandfather, Captain Turner, built that house. No other house in Salem like it. It has seven gables."

Before the wagons came to the big house with seven gables they stopped in front of a weather-beaten little cottage in a weed-grown yard. Mr. Baker began to help Father unload.

Lizza and Nat carried Sammy's cradle into the house. Mother put Sammy in it. She straightened and smiled. "What a lovely big fireplace!"

Granny sniffed. "Big enough to let the heat go up and the wind come down. Much as your life's worth to keep it wooded in the winter." She looked at Nat over her spectacles. "Think you're big enough to go fetch some fire?"

Lizza said, "I'll help!"

"You will not," Granny told her. "That's a man's work. Go along, Nat, and mind your manners."

Nat took the shovel and went down Turner's Lane to the big gloomy house with seven gables. He asked, please, could he borrow some fire?

The maid gave him a shovelful of coals. "You're mighty pindling to be carrying it. Watch you don't spill it."

"I won't spill it," Nat promised. It wasn't so easy, though, to carry the shovelful of coals and keep it level. Halfway home, he thought his arms would pull out of his shoulders.

But he got there with the fire. Mother was ready. She dumped the coals on kindling, and picking up the bellows, puffed air on the coals — gently at first — then harder. The fire sputtered out in red tongues.

Nat grinned and forgot his aching arms. He dusted his hands. "There! What else can I do?"

"Help Lizza weed the yard," Granny said. "A heap of flowers there if the weeds weren't choking them."

Lizza was waiting in the yard. "What's the big secret, Nat?"

He told her about the shilling he had found, and the good-luck spell. "It's the best good-luck spell in the world. But I'll have to do it tonight, sure, while there's still a new moon."

"What if you can't see the new moon through your window?"

Nat shook his head. "That's bad luck. I'll have to wait till Hab is asleep, and then get downstairs in the dark, without knocking over anything, and come out here in the yard."

Lizza's eyes got big. "By yourself? Won't you be afraid?"

"Not very much," Nat said. "Anyway, I got to do it. Our luck's just got to change. I heard Granny talking to Mother. She's worried. She said if things don't go better now, she didn't know what we'd do." Lizza shivered. Nat added quickly. "They will go better, Lizza! Honest they will! Soon as I work my good-luck spell!"

That evening, just after supper, the wind rose, and the rain fell down the wide chimney and hissed in the fire.

Father said, "A nor'easter's brewing. We're in for three days of bad weather."

Lizza gasped. "Oh, no! If it rains . . ." She stopped. Lizza always kept a secret. She and Nat went to the window together and watched the rain slatting down in the weed-grown garden. She whispered, "Nat, there won't be any moon! What'll you do?"

Nat bit his lips. If only he hadn't gone to sleep last night! Now he'd have to wait a whole month, till another new moon, to work his good-luck spell. But he mustn't worry Lizza. Father always said boys took care of girls and women.

"I'll think of something," he promised. He said it again, to try to make it come true. "Sure, I will. I'll think of something."

